

IN SERVICE OF CARE

THE ROLE AND RESOLVE OF INDIAN Doctors

A quiet strength runs through India's healthcare system, rooted not in buildings or machines, but in the people who wear the white coat. As India observed National Doctors' Day on July 1, it marked more than just a commemorative date. Instituted in 1991 to honour Dr. Bidhan Chandra Roy—an iconic physician, a nation builder and former Chief Minister of West Bengal—Doctors' Day is a reminder to reflect on the role of doctors across India, and how their quiet presence continues to shape what care truly means.

DOSE OF EMPATHY

It's often said that a doctor is not just a professional, but a source of comfort for those in pain. Beyond medication and procedures, it's the listening ear, the reassuring glance, and the gentle explanation that bring clarity in moments of uncertainty. From city hospitals to single-doctor clinics in remote corners, India's doctors carry out this task every day, with little fanfare but a deep impact.

General practitioners, surgeons, pediatricians, and specialists form the backbone of public and private care alike. In remote belts, a lone MBBS graduate might be the only medical contact for miles. In maternity wards or oncology units, doctors form lasting emotional bonds with patients and families, often becoming their most trusted counsel. This "healing touch" is not metaphorical; it is lived reality in every Indian district.

DEDICATION AND DAILY SACRIFICE

Few professions demand the kind of personal investment that medicine does. Long hours, missed festivals, and sleepless nights are routine. During the COVID-19 pandemic, this commitment became visible on a national scale, with over 1,600 Indian doctors reportedly losing their lives in the line of duty, according to the Indian Medical Association.

Yet the sacrifices stretch far beyond pandemics. Doctors routinely take on 36-hour shifts, operate through the night, or travel to far-flung health camps. Stories of physicians swimming across rivers to vaccinate children, or staying back after retirement to mentor young interns in underserved districts, aren't uncommon; they just aren't always told.

It's not just physical endurance that's tested, but emotional resilience. The theme for Doctor's Day in 2025—"Who Heals the Healers?"—serves as a timely reminder of what often goes unspoken. Burnout is not merely a personal issue; it's a systemic threat to healthcare delivery. Delivering bad news, managing grief, or constantly being exposed to suffering leaves invisible scars.

While a few private institutions have introduced counselling cells or peer support groups, systemic solutions remain minimal. In the overstretched public system, especially, the mental health of doctors remains largely

